forms in relatively recent times; and it was argued in Chapter 2, that they did so in large part for the purposes of projecting an imperial image. In light of their historical circumstances, the Shansabani elites were surely little interested in the subtleties of epigraphic messaging. Beyond aspiring to monumental precedents – as proposed below – the details of Shah-i Mashhad's complicated inscriptional program were surely left to the more learned, future inhabitants and frequenters of their monumental foundations, *viz*. theologians, jurists, their students, visiting intelligentsia, and literate passers-by.

In the specific case of Shah-i Mashhad, the great variety in content of the *madrasa*'s surviving inscriptions points to expert and intentional epigraphic choices, probably made by its well-read dwellers rather than its royal patron(s). Although no definitive conclusions are forthcoming due to the disappearance of the majority of the complex and its inscriptional program, what remains seems to encompass contradictory trends: while a few of the inscriptions follow epigraphic developments in the eastern Islamic lands and beyond, others notably diverge from them. The northern entrance's verses from Surat al-Hashr (Q. LIX) (Figure 4.7), for example, were not uncommon, particularly in funerary contexts in the Levant, Egypt and the Maghreb from the first two centuries of the Hijira, and in greater Iran as of the eleventh century.[57] The presence of these verses further supports the probability of a tomb within the *madrasa*, perhaps even that of the Shansabani sultan Saif al-Din (discussed above).

By contrast, the presence of a possibly Shi'i Hadith on the northern entrance (Figure 4.9), and the *takbir* of *tashriq* on the southern entrance (Figure 4.7), are both unusual. Quotations from Hadith were rare in the eastern Islamic lands, there being but one documented instance from the early eleventh century,[58] and no known quotations of the *takbir* at all. Shi'i groups had not often suffered persecution since Ghaznavid ascendancy in greater Khurasan, particularly if their activities did not interfere with the political elites.[59] But, even though a Hadith from the Shi'i canon on the *madrasa* would not necessarily be remarkable, it seems improbable that Shi'i instruction would take place there given the Shansabanis' Sunni affiliation. It should also be noted that, in general purport, the quoted Hadith is not dissimilar to Hadith 425 in *Sahih* of al-Bukhari (AH 194/810 CE–AH 256/870 CE), thus generally accepted by the Sunni *madhhab*s.[60] The *takbir* on the southern entrance's interior is currently inexplicable, except possibly as a didactic inscription. Ultimately, the *madrasa*'s surviving epigraphic program not only intimates a sectarian ecumenicalism, it may also point to localized developments that will become clearer after analysis by specialists in Islamic theology and/or further archaeological work.

While much of Shah-i Mashhad's inscriptional program doubtless emerged from the input of the 'ulama' and other learned individuals who would be its future residents, one prominent part of the epigraphy could